

SYDNEY STREETS TO BRADMAN'S BOWRAL: A JOURNEY THROUGH CRICKETING LORE

This diary **captures a cricket lover's journey** through Australia, blending the thrill of the Border-Gavaskar Trophy with Melbourne's cosmopolitan charm and Sydney's dazzling New Year fireworks.

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Melbourne in sprawling Australia, where a majority of its citizens live on the coastal edges of a vast nation, Melbourne is one city that has the big metropolis vibe. Cosmopolitan to the core and multi-racial at its best, there are some localities that exude a distinct

Chinese vibe. There is Chinatown, but even beyond that, the Chinese presence is unmistakable. Restaurants offering oriental cuisine are a dime a dozen, and in high-rises and commercial establishments, the language options are split between English and Mandarin. Many are students, and others are settlers with a Chinese history and an Aussie spirit. In this confluence of civilisations, India takes on Australia in the Boxing

Day Test at the spectacular Melbourne Cricket Ground. This venue is pure theatre, and on this stage, debutant Sam Konstas unleashes sixes against Jasprit Bumrah. It is exhilarating to watch. Cheeky with his shots and chirpy with his words, Konstas leaves a mark. Another youngster, Nitish Kumar Reddy, posts a sparkling century. "I wanted to prove a few people wrong," he later says. The Telugu

New Year festivities: All roads led to the Sydney Harbour Bridge to witness the fireworks at the stroke of midnight. AFP

